On Monday the 13th May we had a sharp shock of an earthquake and we have since learnt that this was felt more severely at Kashan and Meeanna. In the district of Meeanna a town about 100 Miles S. E. of this, many villages were completely thrown down and the town itself half ruined. Numbers of people have been killed and wounded. At Ispahan the great mosque is injured. It is very seldom that earthquakes spread over such an extent of country as this has done. Tabreez appears to have been the extremity on one side and Ispahan on the other. I believe this is the first time Ispahan has been visited by these calamities which may account for its being almost the only decent looking city in Persia. Who in his senses would build a house two or three stories high with the chance of having it come tumbling about his ears as soon as it was finnished.

I dont know whether I ever told you a story of H. R. H. Mallic Cossim Meerza; this man is one of the sons of the late king[71] and is remarkable for his European predilections. He talks French fluently, English pretty well, and Russian a little and he has learnt a little of Geography and Astronomy. He wears European clothes and drinks wine etc. He was lately appointed governor of the town and district of Booroojeerd in the center of Persia, where they have seen very little of Europeans. Soon after his arrival the oolooma (body of the priesthood) waited upon him and preached to him about the sin and scandal of his having adopted the manners and dress of the infidels. The first day he was very civil and gave them evasive answers, the next he remonstrated using the usual arguments of loose fishes in Persia, that his going to a certain hot place would not oblige them to come too, that every one has a right to do as he pleased etc. At last after some days he said "gentlemen have you seen *my* priests, *my* oolooma?" "No," said they, "we have seen nothing like a Mollah about your establishment." "Boys," said he calling to his servants, "open the doors." They did so and H. R. H. gave a long loud whistle, when in rushed greyhounds, Spaniels, pointers, large dogs used for fighting wolves and wild boars, and curs of almost every description. The Mollahs tucked up their robes and began hopping about to avoid being contaminated by touching the dogs and went away spitting right and left and cursing the Prince in the most classic Arabic — They never troubled him again.

(To be continued)

[71] Fath Ali Shah.

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